

Lençóis Maranhenses

A region of sweeping white dunes in northeastern Brazil, seasonally adorned with thousands of crystal-clear turquoise surface pools



Covering some 600 square miles (1,500 square km), Lençóis Maranhenses is one of the most unusual areas of coastal sand dunes in the world. For part of the year, it looks like a desert, but from March to June it receives large amounts of rain, which collects in depressions between the dunes and creates many aquamarine pools. From the air, the vast expanse of dunes and blue pools looks like white bedsheets hung out to dry on a windy day. In fact, the word *lençóis* is Portuguese for “linen.”

▷ SLEEPING FISH

In the dry season, tiger fish, or trahira, burrow down into the sand and lie dormant, reemerging in the pools during the next rainy season.

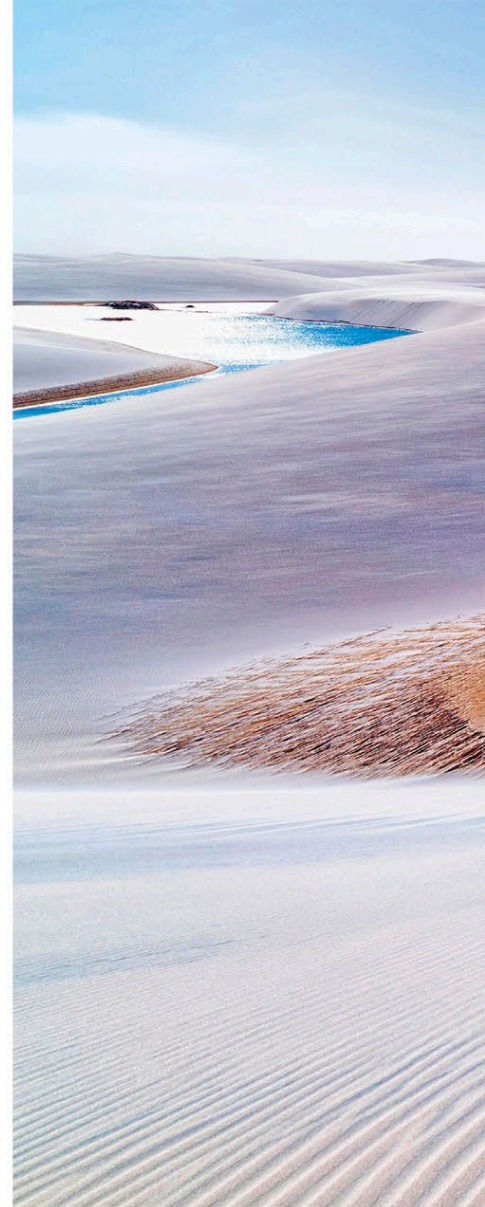


Blue lagoons

The pools, or lagoons, reach their maximum size around the end of the rainy season, in July, and remain so until September. Some are over 295 ft (90 m) long, with temperatures of around 86°F (30°C). Although they exist for only a few months each year, the pools are not devoid of life. Fish can usually access some of the pools via temporary channels that connect them to nearby rivers, such as the Rio Negro. The watery world of Lençóis Maranhenses is a brief one, however.

Once the dry season returns, the hot equatorial sun heats the region, causing the pools to quickly dry up.

In places, the **dunes** stretch **30 miles (50 km)** back **from the coast**



Chilean Fiordland

A mazelike network of fiords, islands, and magnificent, glacier-sculpted rocky landscapes in southern Chile



▽ GLACIAL SKYLINE

In the Beagle Channel, the southern Andes soar behind a lonely lighthouse. Clear skies are rare here as moisture-laden Pacific air cools and forms clouds as it rises.

The Chilean Fiordland is a large region of southern Chile, including part of Tierra del Fuego, which was covered by a massive ice-sheet 10,000 years ago. Today, following the retreat of that ice-sheet, it is an extensive network of fiords—long, narrow sea inlets formed by the flooding of formerly glaciated valleys—and intervening islands. In total, it covers an area of about 21,500 square miles (55,000 square km) to the west of the southern Andes. At the terrestrial ends of some of the fiords, descending from ice-fields that still remain in the southern Andes, are the tongues of huge glaciers, which continuously calve enormous icebergs into the water. On the edges of the fiords, waterfalls cascade down granite walls, while hundreds of bird species feed around the often mist-shrouded coast and islands. Mammals that live along this coast include marine otters, sea lions, and elephant seals.

